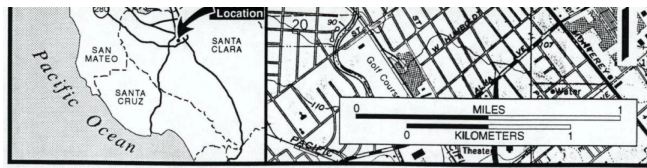


Chinese Cuisines in the US

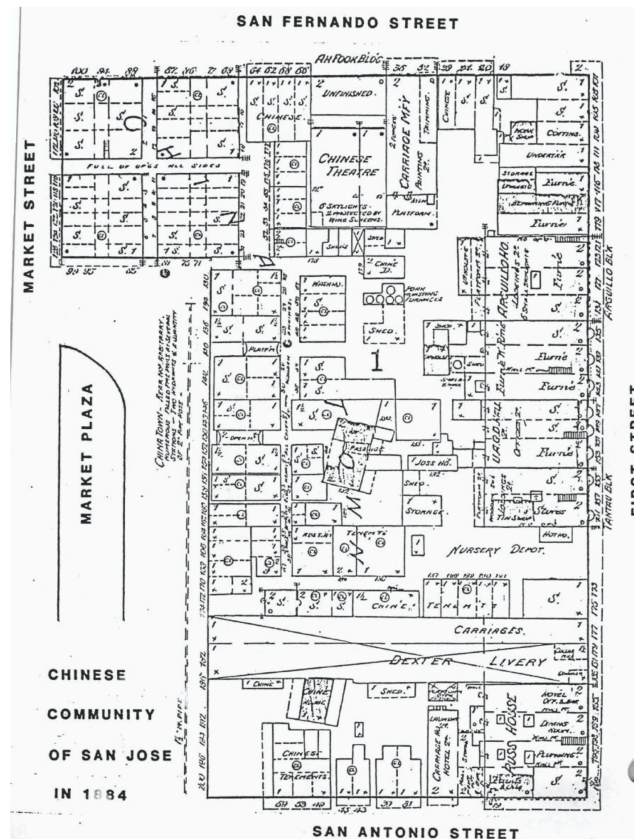
A wonderful example of how early immigrants to the United States maintained their unique cuisine comes from 19th-century California. Chinese immigration to California began at a large scale in the mid-19th century, as individuals and eventually families came to the U.S. for work and new opportunities. These immigrants came from various parts of China, but especially Guangdong, a region with a well-developed local cuisine known in English as Cantonese. While Chinese immigrants settled in various parts of California, they often formed large Chinese communities within the cities of what then was a sparsely populated (and brand-new) US state: San Francisco, San Diego, Sacramento, Oakland, and San Jose. San Jose actually included as many as five "Chinatowns"; Market Street Chinatown, one of the largest, was founded in 1866. It counted more than 1,000 residents with a variety of professions, including many who owned food stores catering to Chinese tastes: groceries, butchers, and restaurants. The Market Street Chinatown was burned to the ground in May 1887 in an act of arson by white neighbors in the context of anti-Chinese sentiment across California. This mind-set culminated in the Chinese Exclusion Act, in place from 1882 to 1943, which prohibited immigration from China and precluded citizenship for individuals of Chinese origin. The Market Street Chinatown was not rebuilt and the Chinese population of San Jose declined substantially.





The location of San Jose and the Market Street Chinatown, with "Block 1" (the area excavated) marked.

Source: USGS



A plot map of Market Street Chinatown in 1884.

Source: Part of the [Sanborn Fire Insurance Company archive](https://www.loc.gov/collections/sanborn-maps/about-this-collection/)
(<https://www.loc.gov/collections/sanborn-maps/about-this-collection/>), now housed in the Library of Congress

Although the destruction of Market Street Chinatown was a disaster for its inhabitants, this fire offers a unique archaeological context for identifying evidence of Chinese—and especially Cantonese—cuisine in the 19th-century United States. Because the area was not rebuilt for decades, the ruins of the markets, stores, and houses of Market Street Chinatown were well preserved. The area was excavated in the 1980s in advance of large-scale construction on the site. In the area excavated, 63 features were uncovered—mostly trash pits, some of which were refuse

from commercial buildings, and others, from tenements (crowded apartment buildings). These included kitchen waste and also waste from pit toilets, which included plant remains that had passed through the human gut undigested—usually, small seeds. Animal bones from these trash pits were numerous and very well preserved.

As part of the Stanford University Market Street Chinatown Archaeology Project (<https://marketstreet.stanford.edu/>), these materials were studied in detail in the early 2000s. Virginia Popper was the paleoethnobotanist on the project, and you read one of her articles interpreting these remains. In her detailed study, more than 60 types of cultivated plant seeds were identified from excavated deposits. Many of these were fruit remains, including *Rubus* sp. (blackberry/raspberry), *Vitis vinifera* (grape), *Citrullus lanatus* (watermelon), *Ficus carica* (fig), *Fragaria* sp. (strawberry), *Prunus persica* (peach), *Litchi chinensis* (litchi), *Dimocarpus longan* (longan), and *Canarium album* (Chinese olive), as well as *Arachis hypogaea* (peanuts—technically not a nut, but the seed of a legume). As noted by Popper (p. 353), these were common snack foods within the Chinese community.

The other plant foods found at Market Street Chinatown included several cereal grains: *Oryza sativa* (rice), as expected for a community with origins in south China, but also *Triticum durum/aestivum* (wheat), *Hordeum vulgare* (barley), *Sorghum bicolor* (sorghum), and *Zea mays* (maize). These were likely underrepresented in the archaeological context due to the method of cooking: If boiled, these grains would likely not be charred and thus would not have been preserved archaeologically. Vegetables were also quite common in these finds, including *Benincasa hispida* var. *hispida* (winter melon), *Momordica charantia* (bitter melon), *B. hispida* var. *chiehqua* (hairy gourd), *Solanum lycopersicum* (tomato), with *Vigna radiata* (mung bean), *Cucumis sativus* (cucumber), and *Solanum melongena* (eggplant); other beans and squashes were less common. Seasoning agents were also found, including *Lentinula edodes* (shiitake mushroom), *Allium* sp. (onion), *Sesamum indicum* (sesame seeds), *Capsicum* sp. (chili pepper), and *Zanthoxylum* sp. (Szechuan pepper). Ceramic containers found in these trash deposits suggest that an assortment of wet and dry preservation methods for pickled and dried vegetables were used to store food, with some containers imported from China rather than produced locally. Animal bones were well preserved—most commonly, pork and beef bones most common, but also significant amounts of chicken, duck, goose, fresh fish, salt fish, egg, and turtle.

The challenge faced by Popper and her colleague Ryan Kennedy, who studied the animal remains, was how to move from these lists of food items to an understanding of Chinese (and Chinese-American) cuisine in 19th-century San Jose. How did Chinese immigrants adapt their traditional foods to the context of California, where the climate and landscape were so different from those of Guangdong? Which plants made the journey with them and were grown in their new home, and which continued to be imported from China? Popper decided to use another source of evidence to interpret these remains: cookbooks.